

Enter the Metaverse for Better or for Worse

If we told you that another universe is evolving in the digital space, where people can live just as in ours, would you believe it or write it off as fan fiction? It is time to take a serious look at the metaverse, which coexists—and even interoperates—with our real world, because it is poised to get bigger.



HoloLens enables collaboration among surgeons worldwide (Courtesy: Microsoft)

You cannot escape the term Metaverse. It stares back at you from the newspapers, television, social media, conferences, investor meets—practically every place except maybe your grandma's living room. (Then again, you might be visiting your grandma in the metaverse!)

Facebook changed the name of the parent company to Meta, while Microsoft is betting big on collaboration using Mesh. Boeing and Airbus want to build their next planes on the metaverse. Barbados is building an embassy in Decentraland. Sotheby's has a store there too, by the way, and Christie's recently sold one of the most expensive pieces of digital art in the metaverse for nearly US\$70 million. Adidas opened a virtual showroom

in The Sandbox, and Ariane Grande performed a grand concert in Fortnite.

People are buying land and building malls and mansions in the metaverse, while youngsters in Philippines are giving up their real-world jobs as they earn more money by winning battles on Axie Infinity. Closer home, people are depositing their cryptocurrency in fixed deposits on Zionverse, while two Potter-heads in Tamil Nadu hosted their Harry Potter themed wedding reception on TardiWorld. The metaverse is all over the place—but what really is it?

The metaverse, 29 years after its conceptualisation

A lot of the advanced technology we see in reality today was once the realm of fiction. Neal Stephenson coined the

term metaverse in his 1992 book *Snow Crash*. He described it as a parallel digital world where humans interact with each other in *avatar* form. Almost three decades later, venture capitalist Matthew Ball describes the metaverse as a massively-scaled and interoperable network of real-time rendered three-dimensional (3D) virtual worlds, which can be experienced synchronously and persistently by an effectively unlimited number of users.

That answers all of you who are asking how the metaverse is different from the massively multi-player online (MMO) games, which are so popular today. The multiverse is not one virtual world—rather, it is a universe that brings together multiple virtual worlds. Over time, the virtual worlds will be